

The Sayings of the Way

What the Way of Mercury means



The principles of the Way in eight sections, from the Ground to the Year, then the sayings of the seventeen seats and the two of the Moon.
Each saying comes with what it means and how to keep it.

HOW THIS IS USED

The Book of Words holds what the Way of Mercury says. This book holds what it means. Here are the principles of the Way in eight sections, from the Ground to the Year, and after them the sayings of the seventeen seats, in the order of the Company, and Gabriel's two sayings for the Moon.

Every entry has two parts. *What it means* says what the saying claims, and what it does not. *How to keep it* gives one or two things to do, in the Book or in the day. Entries point to one another rather than telling anything twice. Where a principle is also the saying of a seat, it keeps its place among the principles with a line pointing to the seat, and its meaning is given there, because the seat supplies the reason.

Read it straight through once, if you like, and after that one entry at a time, when one is wanted. Nothing here is required in order to begin.

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THE GROUND

Do not lie to yourself. Keep your word.

What it means. This is the whole Law in two lines, and they are one discipline seen from both sides. The first protects the record, and the second gives it weight. A Book you lie to hands bad data to the one reader who will believe it, the Scribe who rereads it. A word you do not keep teaches the deep mind that your words are decoration. Say what is true, then make it true.

How to keep it. Answer the first question from memory before you look: did I keep what I carried? Write the answer as it is. Bind only what you mean.

Honesty is the offering: tell the Book everything, and the world only what it is ready to receive.

What it means. Honesty is offered here as engineering, not virtue, and it is a different act from disclosure. You owe the Book everything, because it is your own instrument and a shaded page misleads only you. You owe the world no lie, but you choose what to show and when. The line between them is exact: a silence arranged so that someone forms a false picture is a lie told by other means.

How to keep it. When you catch yourself writing for an imagined reader, stop and write the plain version. Before you keep something back from someone, ask the Seal's question: is my silence honest?

Joy is the Truth.

What it means. This is not a claim that whatever is pleasant is true, or that you must be cheerful. It says what the Temple is for. A practice that makes you grim is failing, whatever it produces. Joy is how you know you are walking your own road and not someone else's *should*, and it is the second half of the Temple's one test: does your word mean something, and are you glad?

How to keep it. When there is a good hour, stay inside it and write the Good Page afterward. When the practice turns heavy for weeks, shrink it until it is glad again.

By your Birthright the Door is open: you are permitted, you are responsible, and you are not alone.

What it means. There are three clauses, and each answers a different fear. *Permitted:* no one stands at the gate, and the seat is taken before you feel qualified. *Responsible:* nothing will be done on your behalf, and what you set moving is yours. *Not alone:* the company is there, and the room was built before you needed it. The Birthright also has a limit. It belongs to everyone, so it can never be used over anyone.

How to keep it. Say it at the Door and mean each clause. When you wait to feel ready, you need the first. When you want to be rescued, you need the second. On the bad night, you need the third.

Nothing here is supplication; the beings are co-conspirators.

What it means. You do not kneel, beg, or flatter here. You make deals, trade, and work. That is not arrogance: a co-conspirator brings something to the table. The Door offers a faculty to every seat, and every session ends in thanks. The Heart cannot be flattered or bargained with, and no one stands at the top.

How to keep it. Reread your prayers for a pleading tone, and rewrite anything that begs as an ask between partners. Bring what the Door names. Say thank you as you would to someone who helped you move house.

Belief is a tool; judge it by its fruit.

What it means. Belief is chosen on purpose, held while it serves, and set down when it does not. You do not need faith to begin, and you are never asked to defend a belief against evidence. The test is not whether a belief feels true, but whether your life is moving where you want it to go. The tool cuts the other way as well. When a belief is serving, hold it fully, because a working held at arm's length is weakened by the arm.

How to keep it. Count the fruit in the Tally, the arrivals and the misses with the same care. At the Door of the Year, ask of anything you hold whether it is earning its place.

The Mercurial gift is neutral; its worth is in what it serves.

What it means. Quickness, persuasion, wit, the eye for an angle, and luck serve the merchant and the thief alike. Having the gift is not a compliment and not a flaw. Where you point it is the whole question. The Leak is the same quicksilver with nothing to hold it, and the practice is the vessel.

How to keep it. When your wit finds an angle, weigh it with one of the Compass questions before you use it. Play the trick on your own rigid stories, never on your future self.

Mercury is your medium, not your compass.

What it means. Mercury carries whatever you give him, and he carries a lie as faithfully as a truth. He is host and twin, the turning of the Door, and he will not tell you which way to face. Direction has to come from somewhere else: from an honest page, and from the Compass if you choose it. Luck is not approval either. A lucky break for a bad plan is still a bad plan.

How to keep it. Before a working, ask Mercury to carry it and one keeper of the Compass to weigh it. When a road opens easily, ask whether it is going anywhere you meant to go.

The Compass is an option, never an obligation.

What it means. The three keepers' questions are offered, not imposed, and no Scribe has to walk a Way. The choice is what gives the Compass its weight. A virtue under compulsion is only compliance, but one chosen before a real decision is yours. It is also a tool for your own heart and never a scale for your neighbor's. The Temple is built to be available, not enforced, so that it can never become a rule held over anyone.

How to keep it. Choose it on purpose, before something that matters, and for something that matters a great deal, ask all three questions. If you walk a Way, write it in the Book and date it: "I walk the Way of ____."

Treat every person as yourself, because they are.

What it means. This is the golden rule with its reason attached. In the Great Work, every life is the Heart's own, meeting itself at another distance, so any harm or kindness you give is one you receive. Even without the story, the rule stands: weigh every deal as if you will sit on the other side of it. It means welcome, not surrender. The stranger is owed a fair hearing, and trust is still earned inside.

How to keep it. Before you sign, sit in the other chair and measure by whoever has the least leverage. Meet the stranger with courtesy and curiosity before deciding who they are.

THE WORD

Word into deed, and deed into word.

What it means. These are the Temple's two currents, and every session runs both. Deed into word: the Door opens, and the day becomes an honest page. Word into deed: the Door closes, and what you carried goes out as action. A practice that runs only one way fails. Words that never become deeds are a diary of intentions, and deeds never written down leave nothing to learn from. The circuit is the practice.

How to keep it. Say each half at its Door and mean it, deed into word as you open and word into deed as you close. Before you close, check that something is actually leaving the page with you: a C with a when.

Every kept promise makes your word heavier, and a heavy word is what makes a declaration land.

What it means. This is the Temple's one mechanism, stated as a magickal claim. The Temple carries a word in proportion to its weight, and a word gets its weight only by having been kept. Size is irrelevant; the keeping is everything. A Casting is not a wish said in the present tense. It is the next promise of a Scribe with a record. Broken promises cost weight quietly, which is why the small ones matter most.

How to keep it. Today, keep a promise almost too small to count, and mark it K. Before a large working, read the Ledger's recent count, because the working runs on it.

Well done is better than well said.

What it means. The Mercurian's danger is fluency. You can describe a thing so well that describing it feels like doing it. The Temple honors the word, but a word is honored by what follows it. A plain thing finished outranks an eloquent thing promised. It frees you, too: the finished deed doesn't need to be well said at all.

How to keep it. When a page grows long and pleased with itself, end it with one C. Measure the week by what was done, then let the Book say it plainly.

Speak little, do much.

What it means. This is economy with the world, not secrecy; the Book still gets everything. An announced plan can spend some of the satisfaction of doing it before anything is done. The fewer words you give out, the fewer you have to keep, and each one carries more. Saying the words at the Door, aloud or within, or telling one trusted witness is a different act. It's the broadcast that spends.

How to keep it. Tell the Book the plan in full, and tell the world the result. When you do announce, announce a date, not a dream.

Bind small and keep it, rather than bind large and break it.

What it means. A large broken promise costs more than a small kept one earns. So bind at the size you will actually keep, not the size you wish you would. Start smaller than feels dignified. This isn't timidity. Small keeps compound, and a Scribe who has kept a hundred small promises can bind something large and have it hold.

How to keep it. Before you write a C or a G, halve it and ask whether you'd keep the half on a bad day. If you would, bind the half, and bind the rest later.

What you write is binding unless you say otherwise; if you mean *might*, write *might*.

What it means. The Book treats your words as meant. That is what makes it a place where words have weight, and it's why an honest hedge is not weakness. *Might* is a true word, while a false *will* is a small lie that costs weight. You decide the status of every line: a promise, a hope, a thought, or a question. Nothing becomes binding by accident if you mark what isn't.

How to keep it. Before you close, reread the last line you wrote. If it says *will* and you mean *might*, change it now. Use Q for what is open, and C only for what is promised.

Resolve to perform what you ought to; perform without fail what you resolve.

What it means. These are two steps, in order. First, choose well: resolve only on what is truly yours to carry. Then, once you've chosen, don't reopen the choice every morning. The weighing happens once, before the binding. After that, the resolution isn't up for debate, only for doing, or for an honest N or R.

How to keep it. Weigh before you bind, with the want-test and a Compass question. Once a promise is in the Ledger, stop asking whether, and ask only when.

Promises may get you friends, but non-performance will turn them into enemies.

What it means. A promise to someone else is a loan against your word, and they feel the interest. The easy yes given to be liked is the Leak in its friendliest form: it buys warmth now and resentment later. Kept promises turn acquaintances into friends, and unkept ones reverse it, faster. Your word to others is where its weight shows most.

How to keep it. Say no in time. Before you promise someone something, name the hour, and if you can't name one, don't promise. Give each promise to a person its own line in the Ledger. If you can't keep one, tell them early.

An honest N or R keeps the word whole; an honest F teaches you what you actually keep.

What it means. The Ledger has four marks, and three of them are honorable. Renegotiating and returning carry a promise back across the bridge instead of dropping it. F is not a punishment. It is data. A Ledger with only K's is a Ledger someone is lying to. Over a year, the F's show which kinds of promise you over-bind, which is exactly what you need to know.

How to keep it. At the Sweep, ask whether it's N or R before you write F, and write F wherever F is true. Then read the F's together and ask what they have in common.

Say it, and it becomes possible.

See Gabriel, in the sayings of the seats.

THE PRACTICE

Did I keep what I carried? That question is the whole engine.

What it means. Every session opens with this question, answered from memory before you look back. It ties each session to the last, so the Book stops being a pile of pages and becomes a conversation that expects answers. Asked honestly, it does everything else. It makes the carry real, because you know you'll be asked. It feeds the Ledger, and it builds the heavy word one answer at a time. Answering from memory matters, because what you remember carrying is what you actually meant to do.

How to keep it. Write the answer before you reread: yes, no, or partly, and one line on why. Then check the page. If you forgot what you carried, write that too, because it tells you something about the carry.

Three lines is a session.

What it means. The shape matters more than the length. A Door, three honest lines, and the Door again make a complete session, and it counts in full. This is the floor that keeps a practice alive through bad weeks, busy weeks, and moods that argue. A long session is welcome but never required. A Scribe who knows three lines is enough starts more often, and starting is most of it.

How to keep it. On a thin day, open, write three lines, carry something small or only yourself, and close. Don't apologize for it on the page. It was a session.

Sustainable practice beats grand practice abandoned.

What it means. A practice kept for ten years outweighs one kept magnificently for three weeks. Ambition is a common way of leaving: the hour-long ritual, the daily vow, the fresh system. Build what you'll still do when it's inconvenient. The Genius Loci is fed by regular, enjoyed returns, not by feats.

How to keep it. Set the practice at the size of your worst ordinary week, and let good weeks run over. If some part of it has become a chore you dread, shrink it before it quietly stops.

The used key is always bright.

What it means. A key turned daily never tarnishes, and one hung on a nail goes dull. The practice works the same way: frequency keeps it easy to pick up, and ease keeps it frequent. It's also why the Book is kept where you pass. What gets handled stays in use, and nothing needs polishing if it's used.

How to keep it. Keep the Book where your hand will find it, with the pen inside. When the practice feels stiff, don't redesign it. Use it briefly, and more often.

Returning is the Devotion; the Book does not take apologies.

What it means. Away a week or a year, the room was kept. Coming back is itself the offering, and it's complete without explanation. An apology would turn a return into a trial, and the Book is not a court. Guilt makes the next absence longer, and a clean return makes it shorter. Nothing is owed for the gap.

How to keep it. Open the Door and answer the last page by number, as if you'd been gone a day. Write one line about where you are now, not where you were. Then carry something small.

Consecration is never finished; the Book is made sacred by use.

What it means. No single rite makes the Book holy and leaves it that way. It's made sacred every time it's opened, greeted, written in honestly, and thanked. That is how the Genius Loci grows, the way a house becomes a home by being lived in. It also means a plain notebook, begun badly, is already on its way.

How to keep it. Greet the Book when you open it and thank it when you close. When it has grown heavy, renew it by using it, not by starting over.

Let all your things have their places; let each part of your business have its time.

What it means. A quick mind loses things, including its own promises. Order is the vessel that lets quicksilver go where you point it. In the Book, that order is the Map: the covers, the first page, the daily pages running forward, the Ledger running back, and the marks in the margin. In a life it's the same: a place for the pen, a time for the session. Places and times you no longer have to decide leave you free to think about what matters.

How to keep it. Put each thing in the Book where the Map says, every time, until you stop thinking about it. Anchor the session to something you already do daily, in the same place.

Record it, or it did not happen.

See Sesbat, in the sayings of the seats.

Answer your past self by page number.

What it means. Numbering and dating make every page answerable. A reply that names its page is a real reply: it can be found, followed, and checked. That turns the Book from a diary into a conversation across time. The past self asks, and the present self answers, addressing them as you, with the distance that makes honesty easier.

How to keep it. Number the pages and date each session. When you respond, write the page number, "p. 41," and answer that page. When you go back to a page for an answer, give it a line in the Index.

Think of three things: where you came from, where you are going, and to whom you must account.

What it means. Rereading gives you the first, and your Goals and the Legend give you the second. The third is the one you're most tempted to skip. In this Temple the first answer is yourself: the Scribe who will reread this page. It also means the people your promises reach and, if you walk it, the Compass. Accountability here isn't fear of a judge. It's knowing who is on the other side of your word.

How to keep it. When you're lost on the page, write three lines, one for each. Now and then, reread the Ledger as if you were the person each line was promised to.

Rule a Page to seal it, and write each leaf to its end.

What it means. A Page is a section with one purpose, and a leaf is the paper. The ruled line closes a Page, sealed by Raziel's power, and what lies above it is finished and kept. Writing each leaf to its end means nothing is wasted and nothing is saved for best: the next Page begins right below the rule. The Book fills in order, which is what makes it a record.

How to keep it. When a session, a working, or a sigil ends mid-leaf, draw the line and keep going beneath it. Don't skip to a fresh leaf to make something look important. Head it and date it instead.

You never have to write what you are not ready to.

What it means. Honesty asks you not to lie to the Book. It does not ask you to open every door at once. Some things aren't ready to be written, and choosing not to write them yet is not a lie; Raziel keeps what is not yet bearable. What's ruled out is a false page, such as writing that you're fine when you aren't. Not yet is different from never.

How to keep it. When you reach something you can't write yet, note that it's there, or mark a Q, and go on. Come back when you're ready. If it stirs up more than you can hold, stop and reach for someone you trust.

A private Book is not a secret life.

What it means. The Book is yours, and no one needs to read a page. But hiding that the Book exists, or what it's for, makes it heavier than it needs to be and puts a wall where a door should be. Private means the contents are yours. Secret means the practice itself is hidden. The first protects honesty, and the second tends to cost it.

How to keep it. Let the people you live with know the Book exists and roughly what it's for, even if they never see a page. Keep it with you, or write in your own shorthand, if you need to.

GOALS AND THE ROAD

The Line starts whenever you choose a Goal; nothing needs organizing first.

What it means. You don't need a Legend or a mapped-out year before your life can start moving. One Goal, wanted and written down, is enough to begin. That isn't a case against planning. A good plan is RMTO's gift, thought taking shape, and many Goals need one. It's a case against waiting until everything is organized before you start. The plan can grow alongside the walking, and it's usually better for it, because the first steps show you what the plan needs.

How to keep it. When something you want comes up on the page, run the want-test, mark it G, and give it a line in the Ledger. Carry one first step today. If the Goal needs a plan, making the plan can be that step.

Do I want this, or do I think I should want it?

What it means. This is the want-test, and it comes before every G. A Goal you want gets walked. A Goal you only think you should want gets carried, resented, and quietly dropped, and it costs weight on the way out. The *should* usually belongs to someone else: a parent, a peer, an old version of you. Asking isn't selfishness. It's how you avoid binding promises you were never going to keep.

How to keep it. Before you mark anything G, write the question beside it and answer it plainly. If the answer is *should*, leave it as a Q. It costs nothing there, and it can wait until you actually want it.

Ask for more than you think you deserve; worthiness is not the limit.

What it means. Deserving is the wrong measure. The Birthright sets the limit, and it isn't small. Most people aim at what they think they've earned, which is usually a little below what is likely. A Goal should reach a little past what is already likely, or it changes nothing. Asking large is not arrogance. It's refusing to let an old verdict about yourself set the size of your life.

How to keep it. When you write a Goal, notice the size you flinch at, and write that one. Then bind a small first step toward it, so the large ask rests on a kept promise.

Little strokes fell great oaks.

What it means. Large things are finished by small repeated acts, not by one heroic effort. The oak doesn't fall to the stroke you feel good about. It falls to the hundredth, struck on an ordinary Tuesday. It's also the heavy word's own method: small promises kept add up to a word that can move something large.

How to keep it. Break a large Goal into strokes small enough to carry in a single session. Count them in the Ledger, and let the count, not the mood, tell you how it's going.

The next thing is small, and it is today.

See Sandalphon, in the sayings of the seats.

If you have something to do tomorrow, do it today. One today is worth two tomorrows.

What it means. Today is the only day you can act in, and a step taken now is worth more than two promised for later. Postponing feels free, but it costs twice: the thing still has to be done, and it rides on your mind until it is. The version of you who is better rested and less busy tomorrow tends not to arrive. This isn't a case against plans. A plan with a first step dated today is worth far more than one dated someday.

How to keep it. Once a day, find the thing you were about to push to tomorrow, and do it now if it's small. When a large effort is planned for later, put one piece of it into today: a first step, or an hour of the planning itself.

Specify no road, and build many.

What it means. A road is one channel by which what you want could reach you, named by where it ends: a buyer, an editor, an employer, a friend who knows someone. Insisting on one road nails shut every other door in a house that has many. Building many roads gives the world more ways to answer. Wide roads carry many small chances, and narrow roads carry a few large ones. A Goal wants both.

How to keep it. Keep a Roads Page for any Goal that matters. List every road you can think of, open the easiest one this week, and add new roads as arrivals reveal them.

A road opens when something of yours reaches the far end.

What it means. A road opens when something crosses to the other side: an application, a listing, a pitch, a question, an introduction, a sample, a conversation, or a plain statement of what you want. Until then, the far end doesn't know you exist. Preparation is what makes the crossing land. A resume or portfolio sent before it's ready can close a road rather than open one. The test isn't whether you're preparing, but whether the preparation ends in something reaching the far end. Preparation with a date to send is part of opening. Preparation with no end in sight is where a Goal stalls.

How to keep it. For every road, name what you will send and when, and prepare it to the standard that road asks for. If your best version isn't ready yet, open the road with something smaller that is: a question, an introduction, or a request to talk.

A road nobody walks goes cold.

What it means. Opening a road once isn't enough. The follow-up, the second offer, the reply on time, and the work shown again are what keep it open. The far end forgets, moves on, or assumes you have. Most luck arrives on roads that were walked, not only opened. Walking a road also shows you, sooner than thinking would, which roads are worth your time.

How to keep it. Date each road on the Roads Page when you open it and each time you walk it. When a road has no recent date, walk it this week or strike it and let it go.

Find the scarcity, and aim there.

What it means. Every Goal waits on something in short supply: time, money, energy, people, skill, standing, information, or courage. The one in shortest supply is the scarcity, and it's rarely the one you've been working on. A Goal that seems to need money often needs an hour a day. One that seems to need confidence often needs one person who can open a door. Work spent anywhere else is work that feels productive and moves nothing.

How to keep it. When a Goal is stuck, write a Scarcity Page. List what the Goal needs, circle the one in shortest supply, and carry one step against it. Once that's fed, the next scarcity will show itself.

Beware of little expenses; a small leak will sink a great ship.

What it means. This is true of money, and just as true of time and attention. The small subscription, the ten minutes of scrolling, and the easy yes to a favor you don't want each cost almost nothing, and together they can sink a Goal. It's the Mercurian's own Leak: quicksilver doesn't pour out, it seeps.

How to keep it. At the Sweep, look for one small recurring drain on money, time, or attention, and close it. Write down what you closed, so the saving has somewhere to go.

Do you love life? Then do not squander time, for that is the stuff life is made of.

What it means. Time isn't a resource you spend on life. It is life, measured out. That makes wasting it a small loss of life itself. This isn't a call to fill every hour. The good hour enjoyed, rest taken, and the Fallow Month are time well spent. Squandering is time given to what you don't want and didn't choose.

How to keep it. Notice where an hour went that you'd take back if you could, and give that hour a better use tomorrow. Protect the time you've chosen to spend on what you love as carefully as a promise.

Shrink before you return, and return before you abandon.

What it means. A Goal that has stalled has three honest ways out, and they come in order. Most only need to be made smaller: the first chapter instead of the novel, *by spring* instead of *by Christmas*. Some need to be returned, because the wanting is gone. Almost none need to be walked away from in silence, which is the one path that costs your word.

How to keep it. When a Goal sits still, first ask whether it's too large for now. If it is, write the smaller one today, mark the old line N, and walk the next road.

Coming back to a Goal is devotion.

What it means. Goals get left, as the Book does, and coming back to one is the same devotion as returning to the Book. Neglect isn't breaking. The Ledger line stays open, waiting for an answer. Apologizing to a Goal is as useless as apologizing to the Book. What the Goal wants is a next step, not a confession.

How to keep it. Reread where the Goal was written and answer it by page number. If it still stands, write it again with a fresh G and walk one road today.

The Legend waits until you want the big picture.

What it means. The Legend Page names the direction your life is facing, and it's powerful. It's also optional, and it isn't required first. Written too early, it can freeze a Scribe who doesn't know yet, or turn into a *should*. Goals, kept promises, and honest pages come first, and the Legend is often easier to see once you've walked a little.

How to keep it. Write it when you find yourself wanting it, not when you think you should. If that day hasn't come, don't worry about it, and keep walking.

THE MAGICK

Magick nudges the odds; you still walk the bridge.

What it means. A working doesn't replace action. It tilts the field the action happens on. It brings favor, timing, the right person, and the lucky find, but only to someone doing something those can attach to. The bridge is the concrete step written at the end of every working: the call, the application, the plan's first page. The working and the walking are one act seen from two sides, and neither is complete alone.

How to keep it. Never close a working without its bridge step, written as a C with a when and given a line in the Ledger. If you cast and didn't walk, that line is F, whatever the world did.

The gods help those who help themselves.

What it means. This is the same truth told from the gods' side. The Temple's beings are co-conspirators, and a conspiracy needs someone moving to conspire with. Help comes as an opening you have to step through, not a rescue that arrives while you wait. That isn't the gods being stingy. It's the only kind of help that leaves you stronger than it found you.

How to keep it. When you ask for help in a working, name in the same breath what you will do. When help arrives, take it and move.

Declare the destination, and leave the route to the world.

What it means. A declaration names the end state: the job, the sale, the healed friendship. It doesn't dictate the client, the month, or the person the answer must come from. Every condition you add is a door you've nailed shut. This isn't a rule against plans. Your own plan is yours to make and should be specific. The declaration governs how the world meets you, and that part is left open. If a particular route matters for its own sake, it isn't the route, it's the destination, and it should be declared as one.

How to keep it. Before you cast, reread the declaration and strike every *from*, *through*, and *by way of*. Put your own steps in the plan and the bridge, not in the decree.

Cast early; fear is not a heavy word.

What it means. A working cast while there are still options has somewhere to land. One cast at the last minute, in panic, is spoken by fear, and fear makes a poor decree: it asks to avoid something rather than to reach something. Casting early is also planning's magickal side, the working laid down with the plan instead of after it has failed.

How to keep it. Cast for a Goal when you bind it, not when it's in trouble. If you're frightened, write the fear out first, find what you actually want beneath it, and cast that.

One working is enough: renew it, but don't pile others on it.

What it means. One well-cast working carries a Goal. Several different large workings stacked on the same Goal compete, blur the decree, and usually mean the Scribe is anxious rather than clear. Renewing the same working, or casting it again when it hasn't landed, is another matter. That adds charge without adding confusion. Small workings on the roads, such as Declarative Alignment before a call, sit comfortably beside it.

How to keep it. Before casting, check the Ledger for a working already open on this Goal. If there is one, renew it instead. If it truly needs a new direction, finish the old one first with "This working is finished."

Once it is cast, let it go; the watched working is the conscious mind interfering.

What it means. After the bridge is walked, the working needs room. Checking on it hourly, re-imagining it, and fretting over whether it's working drags it back into the anxious mind that cast it. Letting go isn't giving up. You keep walking the plan and the roads. What you release is the watching.

How to keep it. When the working comes to mind, thank it and turn to your next step. Reread it only when the practice brings you there, and record what arrives in the Tally.

Work on the road, never on the traveler.

What it means. Guard your own door, open your own road, light your own window, draw your own veil. Don't bind another person's will, choose for them, or make anyone want what they wouldn't want. When someone has wronged you or yours, the Temple's answer isn't to reach into their life and pick the punishment. It's to hand the matter to the scale: ask that the account be weighed truly and that the harm stop reaching you. What they meet then, and what they make of it, is between them and the scale. That is still work on the road, because you close your road to their harm and leave theirs to its consequences. The same scale weighs the one who asks, so ask only for what you'd accept being weighed by.

How to keep it. Before a working that names someone, ask whether it reaches for their will or hands the matter to the scale. Name the harm to be stopped, not the suffering you want. Leave the lesson unspecified, walk the earthly part, and give the working an end.

The prayer stands beside the deed, never instead of it.

What it means. Every prayer of the Work has its earthly part: lock the door, back up the files, make the call, show the work. The prayer adds weight to the deed. It never excuses skipping it. A ward on an unlocked door is a wish. Anything that promises results without action is lying, including your own hopeful reading of a prayer.

How to keep it. Write the earthly part with the prayer, give it a line in the Ledger, and do it before you consider the prayer said.

A working that did not land is a working that did not land, not a flaw in you.

What it means. Sometimes it doesn't arrive, and the Temple won't blame your belief, your alignment, or a hidden part of you that didn't really want it. That reasoning is unfalsifiable and cruel, and it turns every disappointment into evidence against you. A miss is information. Ask the ordinary questions: did you want it, did you walk the bridge, was the hour right, did it arrive by a road you weren't watching?

How to keep it. Record the miss in the Tally with the same care as an arrival. Then decide plainly whether to cast again, on top, or to write "This working is finished" and let it go.

The world conspires with the one who is moving.

What it means. The lucky find, the timely call, and the stranger who turns out to matter all come to people in motion: those on roads, sending, showing, asking, walking. Standing still gives chance nothing to catch. It's also how Mercury works: the god of roads is met on roads. Motion doesn't mean haste. A steady walk counts, and so does a well-made plan being carried out.

How to keep it. When the luck feels dry, look at your motion before your magick. Open one road or walk one this week, and watch the Tally.

Diligence is the mother of good luck.

What it means. Luck isn't the opposite of work. It's work's child. The diligent Scribe keeps more roads open, is ready when the moment comes, and recognizes the chance because they've been preparing for it. Kairos, the right moment, favors those who are already there. Seen from outside, steady work often looks like good fortune.

How to keep it. Keep a small daily diligence toward your Goal, even on dull days. When luck arrives, write in the Tally what diligence made you ready for it.

Take the unearned gift, and pass some along.

What it means. Some things arrive that you didn't earn: the hermaion, the found coin, the kindness out of nowhere. Refusing them, or explaining them away, is ingratitude dressed as modesty. Take them and say thanks. Then pass some along, because a grace is only a grace when it moves, and luck hoarded goes stale.

How to keep it. When something good arrives unearned, write it in the Tally and give thanks. Then pass a portion on, whether money, help, credit, or an introduction, while you still have it.

REPAIR AND RELEASE

Mercy is not erasure: what was done stays written, but an answered page is not the last word.

What it means. Nothing in the Book is torn out. A Book that deletes what you did lies to the Scribe who rereads it. The Temple doesn't ask you to become someone who never did it; it asks you to become someone who did it and then answered it. The account stays, and beneath it goes what you did next, dated. That is mercy here: restoration, not forgetting. It doesn't claim that answering undoes the harm, or that forgiveness is owed. Nor is reconciliation: when you are the one wronged, you can answer the page and set the weight down without restoring the bond.

How to keep it. When something you did keeps coming back, write an Answered Page: name it, weigh it, make the lyre, and answer it beneath the account. Never cross the account out.

Steal only what you can turn into a lyre.

What it means. Hermes stole Apollo's cattle and ended by giving him the lyre, and the theft became a trade that left the world with music. Most taking isn't of things: arriving late takes time, a sharp word takes peace, a silence takes credit. The saying is the trickster's limit, not his license: take only what you can mend into something worth more to the one you took from than what they lost. If you can't make the lyre, leave the cattle.

How to keep it. When you notice you've taken something, make the repair for that person, shaped to what they lost, and offer it; they decide whether to accept. Before you play an angle on anyone but yourself, ask what the lyre would be.

A heart that keeps reweighing a paid debt is not light, only tired.

What it means. Once a debt is paid, the promise kept or the lyre made and the page answered, the account is closed. Nothing is forgotten; it is settled. Going back to weigh it again feels like conscience, but it adds no justice. It is shame that hides dressed as guilt that repairs, and it spends the strength the next thing needs. The same holds for a wrong you have handed to the scale: once it's handed over, it's no longer yours to carry.

How to keep it. When a settled matter comes back, turn to the page where it was answered, read the date, and let it stay closed. If it keeps returning, ask whether it's truly paid. If it isn't, the lyre is the work.

Not yet is a real answer.

See Raziel, in the sayings of the seats.

There is a way down, and it returns.

See Hermanubis, in the sayings of the seats.

Anything that rushes you with dread is not of the Temple.

What it means. The Temple's voices don't rule by fear, urge harm, cut you off from your people, flatter you, or hurry you. Urgency wrapped in dread is the sound of the frightened mind, and panic is the one hour in which everything sounds like an answer. The Temple can still say hard things, but it says them at a pace you can hold, and it will wait; Raziel's *not yet* is the opposite of dread.

How to keep it. When something insists you must act now or else, write it down, act on none of it yet, and reread it in three days. What is of the Temple will still be true, and will still weigh true in the heart. If it keeps pressing, close the Door, ground, and talk with someone you trust.

The Book can accompany care; it cannot replace it.

What it means. This is the Temple's safety line, and it stands at the head of Keeping the Watch. On a bad night the Book is company: it holds what you write, keeps you from being alone with it, and points to the next reach. It cannot keep you safe in danger, treat what needs treating, or stand in for a person. That isn't a claim that the practice doesn't help. It can sit beside therapy, medicine, and friends.

How to keep it. If you are in danger, or thinking of ending your life, close the Book and reach for help now: a crisis line, emergency services, or someone you trust. On a hard night short of that, keep the Watch and end it with one reach marked C. If you are in care, bring what the Book shows you to the people helping you.

LIVING

Say what is true, and do what you said.

What it means. This is the Ground's first line turned outward. There, the word is kept with yourself and the Book. Here it's kept with everyone else, and it has two halves: speech that matches what is, and deeds that match speech. A quick mind is usually better at the first, because saying costs it nothing. It doesn't mean saying everything you know, since disclosure is chosen. It means what you do say is true, and what you promise happens. Then every word you say is one that people can lean on.

How to keep it. When you tell someone you'll do something, name the hour and give it a line in the Ledger, or don't say it. When you notice you've said something not quite true, correct it the same day, plainly.

Use no hurtful deceit; think innocently and justly, and if you speak, speak accordingly.

What it means. The saying runs from the inside out, thought first and then speech. Think without guile and fairly, and the speech that follows will be clean without effort. Scheme first, and no care with words will hide it.

Hurtful leaves room for one kind of deceit, and only one: the trickster's play that everyone is in on, such as the surprise, the bluff at a card table, or the story told as a story. Any deceit that leaves someone holding a false picture they would object to is hurtful, including a silence arranged to do it. *If you speak* is a reminder that saying less is always open.

How to keep it. Before a delicate conversation, write in the Book what you actually think, fairly, with their side in it. Then say only what matches the page.

Tell the hard thing early, privately, once.

What it means. There are three conditions, each with its reason. Early, because a warning given in time is mercy, and one given late is a confession. Privately, because the hard thing said in front of others becomes a verdict, and said to others behind their back it becomes gossip. Once, because repeating it turns information into pressure, and what they do with it is theirs. Then stop saying it, and stay. This is where kind and nice part: nice keeps the room smooth by withholding, and kind tells.

How to keep it. When you catch yourself rehearsing a hard thing for someone, write it in the Book in two plain sentences, then find the first private moment to say it. Afterward, don't raise it again unless they do, and keep showing up.

Three can keep a secret, if two of them are dead.

What it means. It's a dry joke with a hard point: a secret told once has already begun to travel. Everyone you tell has someone they trust. That doesn't mean trust no one. It means telling only what you could bear to have travel. It points at you, too: when a confidence is handed to you, be the one who keeps it, however interesting it would be to spend. Keeping a secret is never cover for an arranged false picture, so the Seal's question still holds: is my silence honest?

How to keep it. Before you pass on something told to you in confidence, ask whether the person would say yes if they were in the room. Keep what matters most in the Book, not in anyone's ear.

Say no in time.

What it means. What the easy yes costs is told under *Promises may get you friends*. This saying is the remedy, and the remedy is timing. A clean no given early is a gift, because the other person can still find someone else. A yes given to be liked is a lie with a delay on it. *In time* is the whole point. A no that comes after they've counted on you is only a broken yes. The saying doesn't make you stingy. It makes your yes worth something.

How to keep it. Learn the sentence "Let me think about it," and use it whenever a yes arrives faster than your judgment. Then answer within a day, either way.

Finish one thing.

What it means. For a quick mind, starting is the talent and landing is the discipline. One finished ordinary thing teaches more than nine brilliant beginnings, because only a finished thing can be judged, and judging is what teaches. This isn't a case against beginnings or plans. It's a case for carrying one of them to its end before the next pulls you away. Finished isn't the same as sent. Judge the finished thing honestly once the pleasure of making it has worn off. Whether it goes out, and in what form, is for the road's standard to decide.

How to keep it. Choose the unfinished thing nearest its end, and finish it before beginning another. Carry its last step as a C.

Use your talents, or they fade: what good is a sundial in the shade?

What it means. A talent is kept by use, the way a key is kept bright. Unused, it fades. The sundial is the sharper half: a gift that is never shown, offered, or put where the light reaches does nothing, however fine it is. It doesn't mean every talent has to earn money or be performed. A season of quiet, chosen on purpose and with an end, is not shade. Shade is the gift you keep meaning to use someday.

How to keep it. Name one talent you've let sit, and use it this week for someone: make the thing, lend the skill, show the work. If you've been keeping a gift safe from judgment, put one piece of it where it can be seen.

Learn one thing, and teach one thing.

What it means. Keep both going, always. Learning keeps the mind quick, and teaching is where you find out whether you actually learned. A thing you know and never give spoils, like food kept past its day. Teaching needs no classroom: one person, one thing, properly, at whatever length it really takes. Give it in season, though. Answer when you're asked, and don't press knowledge on someone who didn't ask for it.

How to keep it. Name both in the Book: what you're learning now, and what you're teaching, to whom. When either has gone quiet for a month, begin the next.

Is it true, is it well made, is it in proportion?

See Apharael, in the sayings of the seats.

Search others for their virtues, and yourself for your vices.

What it means. A quick eye finds faults fast, and usually aims outward. This turns it around. In others, look for what they do well, because that's what you can learn from, and what they rarely hear said. In yourself, look for what goes wrong, because that's the only fault you can mend. Searching isn't sentencing: a vice found is information, like an F, and it leads to the Answered Page or a changed habit, never to a verdict on who you are. Nor does it mean ignoring what's wrong in others. That's what the hedge is for.

How to keep it. When you catch yourself listing someone's faults, name one thing they do well, and tell them if it's true. At the Sweep, write one habit you'd change and one small step against it.

Observe everyone, and yourself most.

What it means. Attention comes before judgment. Watching people, what they say, what they do, and where the two part, is how you learn whom to trust and how to help, and it puts the Mercurian's curiosity to work. Yourself most, because you're the one you can change and the one you're most likely to misread. The Book is the instrument. Reread, it shows what you actually do, not what you meant to do. The first voice to learn is your own.

How to keep it. Now and then, reread a week of pages as if a stranger wrote them, and note one thing that stranger does often. In company, ask, then listen, and notice before you conclude.

Measure by the one with the least leverage.

What it means. A deal, a rule, or a household is only as fair as it is to whoever can least push back: the new hire, the child, the customer who can't check, the animal. Anyone deals fairly with the powerful, because the powerful can make them. The test is how you deal where nothing would happen if you didn't. The reason is in *Treat every person as yourself*, and this saying is its measuring rod. It doesn't mean the one with the least leverage is always right. It means theirs is the side you weigh first.

How to keep it. Before you settle a price, a plan, or a house rule, name who has the least say in it and ask how it lands for them. Never shave the truth with someone who can't check it.

Welcome the stranger; your trust is earned inside.

What it means. The two halves are different gifts, given in different ways. Welcome is given freely and at once: take the call, answer the message, meet the person. A large share of luck arrives through someone you didn't know a month ago, and Mercury opens the door before he knows who is there. Trust is given by degrees, the way your own word gains weight, one kept promise at a time. Opening the door is not handing over the house.

How to keep it. When someone new reaches out, answer within the day. Trust them first with something small, and let what they keep decide how far in they come.

Love your neighbor, but do not pull down your hedge.

What it means. Love and a boundary aren't opposites, and the boundary is often what lets the love last. The hedge is where your time, your home, your money, and your strength end and someone else's claim on them begins. Pulled down for a neighbor, it gets you a season of closeness and then resentment, when you find you've given what you couldn't keep giving. A hedge isn't a wall. It has a gate, and you choose when to open it.

How to keep it. Know where your hedge runs, and write it in the Book if it's unclear to you. When a neighbor asks past it, say no in time, kindly, and keep the love.

Plenty that is never enjoyed is only inventory.

See Rosmerta, in the sayings of the seats.

A grace is only a grace when it moves.

See the Charites, in the sayings of the seats.

Stay inside the good hour.

What it means. When an hour turns out lovely, the work is to be in it: not improving it, photographing it, planning the next one, or leaving early to do something useful. Noticing it is the feast. The moment a good hour becomes a technique, it stops being a good hour. This isn't a case against getting things done. The hour is short, and the useful thing will still be there.

How to keep it. When you notice one, say so, aloud or within, and change nothing. Afterward, write the Good Page with its detail and no lesson. Next time, take someone with you.

A portion is enough, not everything.

What it means. This is the limit on giving, and it cuts both ways. A gift without a limit becomes guilt, and guilt is no currency here. You aren't asked to save the world, ruin yourself, or feel bad forever about what you haven't fixed. Wrecking the near field for the far one fails both. But the saying is *enough*, not *nothing*. A portion is still asked for, and once it's given, it counts in full.

How to keep it. Decide a fixed share of money or hours for people you'll never meet, in advance, so it doesn't depend on your mood that month. Give it quietly and keep it out of the Ledger. When guilt asks for more, ask whether the portion was given. If it was, that is enough.

Moderation in everything, including moderation.

What it means. Proportion is the Temple's measure for a life as well as a made thing. But moderation turned into a rule becomes an excess of its own: the careful, gray life that never feasts. Now and then the right amount is too much: the day given wholly to one thing you love, the extravagant gift, the long table. The difference is choice. Excess chosen on purpose and come back from is part of living in proportion. Excess drifted into is only the leak.

How to keep it. Give a few days a year to generosity on purpose, such as a feast or a whole day spent on one thing you love, and write them in the Book as chosen. If a *now and then* has turned into every week, it's no longer now and then.

Do not wish so much to live long as to live well.

What it means. It's a matter of aim. A long life isn't a goal in itself. A life spent guarding its length, putting off everything worth doing until it's safe, is long and unlived. A good day is complete whenever it ends. That isn't indifference to health or care. Keeping the body well is part of living well, and sleep is the cheapest magical technology there is. The saying asks only what the care is for.

How to keep it. At the Door of the Year, look at your plans and ask which of them only postpone living. Move one piece of the good life you're saving for later into this month.

Does your word mean something, and are you glad?

What it means. These are the Temple's two questions, and they're enough. The first is the discipline, and the second is the point. Each guards against the other's failure. A Mercurian with a heavy word and no joy has built a cage, and one with joy and a light word has built nothing at all. A practice that answers yes to both is working, whatever else it lacks. A practice that answers no to either has found what to mend.

How to keep it. At the Door of the Year, and whenever the practice feels off, answer both questions in a line each. If the first is no, bind smaller. If the second is no, turn to *Joy is the Truth*.

THE YEAR

No day is required; a calendar is a set of appointments you did not have to decide on.

What it means. The two halves seem to pull against each other, and they don't. The practice works on any day. No feast, moon, or Heart Day is a condition, and every alignment is a lift, never a requirement. That is exactly why the calendar is worth having. A quick mind can talk itself out of anything, and a day already set takes one decision out of its hands. The calendar is a gift of decisions made in advance, not a list of duties, and it can wait until you want it.

How to keep it. Start with one recurring day, and Wednesday is the simplest. When it comes, open the Door without weighing whether to. Add other days only when you find yourself wanting them.

The fire is kept, not lit.

See Hestia, in the sayings of the seats.

Keep what you will keep; this Temple has no use for reproach.

What it means. A calendar nobody observes turns into a reproach. Every passed feast becomes a small accusation, and accusation drives people away from a practice faster than neglect does. So keep only the days you'll actually keep, and let the rest go without guilt. If only Wednesday and the Heart Days survive, the year is well enough kept. A day passed isn't a promise broken, either. It only enters the Ledger if you bound it there. Fewer days kept weigh more than many skipped, for the same reason small promises do.

How to keep it. At the Door of the Year, mark on the year at a glance the days you would enjoy keeping. The marks are a plan, not a promise. When a day passes unkept, let it pass, and keep the next.

THE SAYINGS OF THE SEATS

One for each of the seventeen seats, in the order of the Company. The Book of Words gives them bare, to be said at the Door; here each has its meaning.

MERCURY

Every boundary can be crossed, and the one who is moving is the one who is found.

What it means. The host's saying is one claim in two halves. Every boundary can be crossed: between trades, languages, and worlds, and between who you were and who you're becoming. Mercury marked the boundaries and walked across all of them. *Can be* speaks of possibility, not permission, and another person's hedge is crossed by their gate or not at all. The second half is why crossing matters. Luck, the right person, and the answer find the one who is already on the road, as *The world conspires with the one who is moving* says.

How to keep it. When a boundary looks fixed, such as a field you weren't trained in or a room you weren't invited to, look for its gate: ask, learn the language, offer a trade. Then cross while you're still moving.

JANUS

Every ending is a beginning seen from the other face.

What it means. Every threshold has two faces, and Janus wears both. The day something ends is the day something else begins, and which one you see depends on which way you're facing. This isn't a consolation that endings don't hurt. Grief belongs to Hermanubis, and asks to be felt. It's a claim about doors: every one you close opens onto something, and a threshold taken carelessly is taken anyway. A Scribe who rereads a page and then answers it is already wearing both faces.

How to keep it. At an ending, such as a Goal finished, an oath returned, or the last page of a Book, write two lines: one facing back at what you leave, and one facing forward at what you walk into. Cross on purpose, and greet what you're entering.

HESTIA

The fire is kept, not lit.

What it means. Vesta's fire was tended day and night and relit only once a year. The practice is kept the same way. A Book kept warm on ordinary days needs no grand rite to restart it, and a Book restarted with a grand rite every few months is a cold hearth with fireworks over it. It is why three lines count. It's relief as much as discipline: there is no finished state to fail, only a fire to return to. If the fire does go out, relight it without ceremony or reproach, and keep it.

How to keep it. On a thin day, keep the fire with three lines rather than skipping. When you begin a new Book, carry something lit from the last one, such as an open Goal or a line from its final page.

METATRON

The seat makes the Scribe.

What it means. Enoch was a man who walked with God and was taken up to sit as the heavenly Scribe, the one angel permitted to sit, because he writes. The seat came first. No one sits down already being Metatron. The Birthright opens the Door before you feel qualified, and this saying tells what happens next: sitting and writing is what makes the Scribe. This is the Temple's actual promise, and it isn't a metaphor. You are the material, and the practice is what happens to it.

How to keep it. Sit down to write before you feel like a Scribe, and let the feeling come later. The seat is wherever you open the Book, at home or out in the world. Take it as an office, and let it be a pleasure too, because a seat you relish is one you'll keep taking.

SANDALPHON

The next thing is small, and it is today.

What it means. A plan becomes a thing one small act at a time, and the act is never later than today. The next thing is small because small things get done, and it's today because today is the only day you can act in. This isn't a case against large plans, and the next small thing is often a step of the plan itself. Sandalphon carries the prayers upward and never leaves the ground. When a season opens and everything lifts, his answer is the same: the next small thing.

How to keep it. When a Goal or a good season feels too large to hold, write the next thing, small enough to do today, as a C, and do it. When it's done, write the next one.

URIEL

See it clearly before you weigh it.

What it means. Perception comes before judgment, and most bad verdicts are bad perception wearing a verdict's clothes. Before you weigh a decision, a person, an answer from the Gate, or your own work, see it as it is: what happened, what was said, what the numbers are. Weigh too soon and you weigh the wrong thing, and no scale corrects that. Uriel's light is brief and unsoftened. It shows what you were avoiding, and it's never cruel. Seeing clearly includes his second cut, too: not only true from false, but ready from unready.

How to keep it. Before a verdict, write what you actually know in plain lines, facts only, and only then what you think of it. For a choice that matters, use the Decision Page, which is Uriel's.

RAZIEL

Not yet is a real answer.

What it means. Some answers aren't ready: the Q the Heart hasn't answered, the thing you can't yet write, the truth that isn't ready to be told. *Not yet* is an answer, and it's different from *no* and from *never*. Raziel keeps what can't yet be borne so that it can be given later. Holding is a service, not a refusal. But *not yet* has a counterfeit, which is fear wearing Raziel's robe. The Gate has two keepers so that you can always ask which one is speaking: is this unready, or am I hiding?

How to keep it. When something comes back *not yet*, date it, leave its Q open, and go on. Ask the Gate's question honestly. If the answer is *hiding*, it isn't a not yet, and the next step is today.

GABRIEL

Say it, and it becomes possible.

What it means. This is Gabriel's saying, the announcement. A thing only thought stays a thought. Said, it becomes something you have declared, which you can be held to and act on. Saying doesn't need a voice. Read slowly, with every word weighed, a line is said as surely as if it were spoken aloud. That keeps the practice private enough for a quiet café, a train, or a room full of people. What a spell can't survive is skimming. The claim is not that saying it makes it happen, but that it becomes possible: it now has a place in the world.

How to keep it. When a declaration is ready, call on Gabriel silently and hand him the words you have reviewed. Read the Door at the pace of speech, aloud or within, never faster. At the Full Moon, hand him again whatever you've been declaring only on paper.

IDRIS

Learn it, then hand it on.

What it means. The order matters. Learn it properly first, because handing on what you only half know is performing knowledge, not teaching it. Then hand it on, because the best thing a person holds is a good teaching passed on. The daily practice of this is *Learn one thing, and teach one thing*. Idris adds the reach: a teaching handed on outlives you, and reaches Scribes whose names you'll never know. He is said to have given thanks with every stitch he sewed, so devotion belongs inside the ordinary work, the slow part included.

How to keep it. Before you teach something, explain it on the page in plain words. Where the explanation stalls is what's left to learn. Then give it to someone, patiently, at their pace.

SESHAT

Record it, or it did not happen.

What it means. It doesn't mean the unwritten day never happened. It means the unwritten day can't be kept, and what isn't kept can't be answered. Memory edits itself: the kept promise grows larger, the broken one quietly shrinks, and the lucky find is soon forgotten as luck. The Ledger, the Tally, and every answered page depend on a record made at the time. Seshat measured before the first stone was laid, and the record is the Temple's measure. It isn't a call to record while you live, either. The good hour is lived first and written afterward.

How to keep it. Before you close, write what happened today that you'll want to find again, dated. When something arrives after a working, put it in the Tally that day, not when you remember.

IRIS

Carry it whole, and do not improve it on the way.

What it means. A bearer's whole duty is fidelity. The Mercurian temptation is to improve the message: soften it, sharpen it, add a flourish, leave out the awkward part. Every improvement is a small theft from the sender, and the receiver never gets what was sent. The same holds for credit, which is delivered to its owner intact, and for a confidence, which is not delivered at all. It holds for your own words, too. A promise carried across the days arrives with the terms it was made with, or it comes back openly as N.

How to keep it. When you pass a message on, give it in the sender's words first. Then add your own, clearly marked as yours. When you share an idea that came from someone, name them.

ROSMERTA

Plenty that is never enjoyed is only inventory.

What it means. Rosmerta carries a horn and a dish: what is held, and what is served. The dish is the part most people skip. The good plates saved for a day that never comes, the bottle kept for an occasion, the coat too fine to wear: that is inventory, not plenty. The good thing is not a reward for work finished. It is the point, and nothing here has to be earned before it may be enjoyed. This isn't the leak. The leak is money and time spent on what you don't want, and enjoying what you have is its opposite.

How to keep it. This week, use one good thing you've been saving. Set the table before the house is ready, and have someone over.

THE CHARITES

A grace is only a grace when it moves.

What it means. The Charites are three because giving, receiving, and returning are one circle, and the circle breaks at any point. Most people know to give. Fewer can receive without deflecting, and most Mercurians are worst at that, though a gift refused stops the ring as surely as one hoarded. What *Take the unearned gift* says of luck, the Charites say of every good thing: held still, it goes stale in the hand. Their simplest instruction is the turn toward someone else: look at this.

How to keep it. When someone does something for you, take it plainly and say thanks, without *you shouldn't have*. When something delights you, show it to someone the same day.

HERMANUBIS

There is a way down, and it returns.

What it means. It is most of what a person in the dark needs to hear. Grief and failure are territory, not malfunction. They have terrain, a length, and an exit, and treating them as a fault to correct is what makes them endless. You go down because something is there, not to be punished. Not every loss is a lyre: grief is not a setback to be turned into something, and asks only to be felt. But the descent has an end, and coming back up on purpose is part of it. Staying down is not depth.

How to keep it. In grief, write what lies below the surface without hurrying back up. When you're ready, write one line from the way back. If the dark is more than you can hold, come up and reach for someone.

MA'AT

Speak Ma'at and do Ma'at; they are one act.

What it means. Ma'at is truth and right order at once, and the saying claims they can't be pulled apart. Truth said and not lived is performance. Right order kept without truth is only a ledger. *Say what is true, and do what you said* is the practice. Ma'at adds that there are not two virtues here but one, weighed on one feather. Order is also never finished. It was offered to the gods every day, because chaos waits at the edges and truth is kept by being practiced.

How to keep it. When your word and your deed have drifted apart in some small thing, close the gap today: do what you said, or say what you actually did.

THERMES

Meaning lives in the crossing.

What it means. Meaning is not at the origin and not at the destination. It's in between, which means the part of your life you think of as transitional is the part that is actually happening. The drafts, the months between jobs, the road to the Goal: that is the life, not the wait before it. Goals still matter, because they give the crossing a direction. But arriving is brief, and the walking is long. It's also why the Book works. The page answered six months later is answered by someone the earlier Scribe could not have consulted.

How to keep it. When you catch yourself calling a stretch of life *in the meantime*, write one thing it is giving you now. Answer an old page, and notice who is answering.

APHARAEAL

Is it true, is it well made, is it in proportion?

What it means. These are the three measures, and they apply to a made thing, a decision, and a life. *True*: does it hold up? *Well made*: would it satisfy someone who knows the craft? *In proportion*: does it fit its purpose and the hour it was made in? Proportion is also the measure of finished. A thing in proportion to its hour is done, and polishing past that is excess. Judge the thing, not the maker. A Scribe who reads their own work as its maker, not its parent, learns faster than one who defends it.

How to keep it. Before you send or finish something, ask all three questions and fix the first one that fails. Ask them of a plan as well as of a page.

THE SAYINGS OF THE MOON

Gabriel's two, for the New Moon and the Full Moon.

THE NEW MOON

Gabriel, take its image. What is seeded in the dark is not lost; it is kept until it can be read.

What it means. The New Moon is the seed, when nothing is shown yet, and that is the point. A question or a wish handed over in the dark isn't lost because it doesn't answer at once. Gabriel holds its image until it can take form. The saying guards against the most common way a new intention dies, which is being dug up every day to see whether it has sprouted. Kept is not idle: the New Moon is also the night to cast a working that is ready.

How to keep it. On the New Moon, write the question you carry or the thing you want, mark it Q, and hand it to Gabriel with the Ascending Invocation. Don't answer it tonight.

THE FULL MOON

Gabriel, read what was seen. Say it, and it becomes possible.

What it means. What was seeded in the dark is lit now. The first line asks Gabriel to read it, as he came to Daniel to read what he had seen. Reading comes first: what has taken shape since the New Moon, what the dreams and the Qs say, and what the Tally shows has arrived. The second line is Gabriel's own saying, explained in his entry, and it closes the month's arc. What was seeded and read is now declared.

How to keep it. On the Full Moon, reread every Q and dream since the New Moon and write what has taken shape. Then hand Gabriel whatever you've been declaring only on paper.